

4

Patristic Psychology: The Authority of Faith

Dark Ages?

The period covering the decline of classical Roman civilization and the emergence of the Christian world in Europe includes within it an allegedly “dark” episode of unbridled superstition and paralysis of intellect. We must be wary of that Renaissance habit of treating everything separating their own time from classical Greece and Rome as “dark” and “medieval.” Whom do we find when we thumb the pages of these centuries? Epictetus, Origen, Plotinus, Porphyry, St. Jerome, St. Augustine, Boethius, St. Anselm, Peter Abailard (Abe-lard), Robert Grosseteste, Roger Bacon, Thomas Aquinas, William of Ockham—this is the short list. And amidst their writings and achievements we also note the veritable invention of the university as we know it; the construction of more than a hundred “Gothic” cathedrals, each an architectural masterpiece; and the codification and promulgation of Roman law, modified to meet local conditions and laying the foundations for a unified culture and civilization. Not too dark, then, after all.

True enough, from roughly 500 to 800 A.D. the lamps of comprehension and genius are dim, the record of enduring accomplishment almost vanishingly thin. If there is a culprit to be named here, however, it is not the orthodoxies or superstitions of a Christian church but the utter collapse from within, and assaults from without, of all that was Roman civilization. During the early Christian era the cities were politically corrupt, financially and morally wayward. The now deified emperors were of a generally sorry character. Their official biographers provided the *Scriptores Historiae Augustae*, a lasting testimony to those special inanities bred by absolute power. For much of the time Athens was still the target of the philosophical pilgrim and Greek was the language of the learned. By the reign of Justinian, however, it had become a dead language in Rome, another sign of cultural collapse. A surer sign, however, was the contagious *nostalgia* expressed by the better minds of the period.

From the Hellenistic to the Patristic

The Epicurean universe of the "atoms and a void" was a nearly senseless din orchestrated by matter in conflict and by an indifferent destiny. Man's only hope was for a life reconciled to knowable natural law and one passed among friends. While preaching the indestructibility of matter, Epicurus still denied the material soul the ability to retain a meaningful existence once the body "is broken up." Epictetus, reflecting on this Epicurean materialism, had this to say:

Epicurus understands as well as we do that we are by nature social beings, but having once placed our good not in the spirit but in the husk which contains it, he cannot say anything different.¹

ESTOIC
once the material is placed - no meaning

Epictetus was committed to a useful philosophy. He scorned those whose lessons were contrary to common sense or private experience. Just as he insisted upon philosophers living the philosophical life and not merely talking about it, he also insisted upon a philosophy that formally acknowledged what every sentient being knew to be true. One such fact, of course, was the reality of the will and its essentially spiritual nature. Unlike Epicurus, who reduced prophecy to charlatanism, Epictetus was willing to accept spiritual commerce with the future but condemned those who sought it as weak and fearful (Book II, VII).² The Epicurean injunctions against marriage and children were ridiculed by Epictetus as removing the very foundation of social life (Book III, VII).³ The Platonist suspicion regarding the evidence of the senses was viewed with equal contempt, since Epictetus had little to say to one who "has sensation and pretends that he has not; he is worse than dead" (Book I, VI).⁴ In all, Epictetus reasserted the central position of reason in the affairs of life; the indispensability and accuracy of perception when guided by reason; the power of the individual will to withstand the commands of princes and kings; the true happiness of a life devoted to harmony with nature and to rational principles; the transitoriness of wealth, popularity, and worldly power; and goodness as the end of human life. To these he added monotheism, convinced, like Aristotle, that heaven must have one ruler as every flock has one shepherd and every family one father. ← *very mythological*

will appeal to Christians

Marcus Aurelius was greatly influenced by the *Discourses* of Epictetus and, if only for this reason, Rome's official philosophy was Stoical until well into the third century. However, the Romans themselves had moved some distance from the reserved and resourceful lives advocated by Zeno, Cleanthes, and Epictetus. We are on surer footing to read Epictetus as an example of what philosophy was fighting, not what it was observing. The literati among Epictetus' contemporaries were moved more by Horace, Martial, and Juvenal. Indeed, by a deft corruption of Epicurean teaching, the upper-class Roman of the second century traduced philosophical materialism into a rationale for sexual

promiscuity, moral laxity, and general debauchery. Nero's reign (54–68) had set the tone and, within a half century, Romans forgot that he had been judged an enemy of state. They recalled instead only that degeneracy was a sign of power.

As the empire proceeded along the course of its destruction, two radically different remedies were available: Stoic resignation, virtue, and independence and skeptical indifference and ridicule. The former, for obvious reasons, was unacceptable to the free-living aristocrats whose station in life depended upon the good will of the emperor. Skepticism, unless reduced to comedy, is always too subtle and too removed to be adopted by the ordinary run of citizens. In declaring man to be basically a rational animal (Plato), a social animal (Aristotle), and a moral animal (Epictetus), the philosophers of antiquity recognized only generally that we are *psychological* animals at base. Thus, to declare our perceptions to be always illusory or correct is to tell us what we know or firmly believe to be false. To say we are merely matter is, in terms of daily realities of life, to state the useless. To assure us that the laws of nature will see us through the hard times when a Caesar's caprice ever threatens life itself, when Vandals threaten to destroy our culture, or when plague succeeds in killing the children is to remove all philosophy from serious consideration. Thus, at a time when life violated Stoic orderliness in every conceivable way, one could subscribe to Stoic doctrine only by denying that reality was real, or, following the Skeptic, by suspending all judgment entirely. Neither alternative was any more compelling in the second and third centuries than it is now.

The conspiracy of circumstances that led to the rise of Christianity can only be rather generally fathomed. Of the overall political and moral conditions it is important to note the waves of migration by Germanic and Frankish tribes into Rome and its once imperial world. The immigrants, now in power, brought their own traditions and cultish beliefs, these mixing with Roman and Christian attitudes in various and sometimes exotic ways. As it became ever more important for the leaders of this new world to make peace with Christianity, changes were worked in both directions. More will be said of this in the next chapter.

With the breakdown of traditional Roman practices and perspectives, there came a mounting and ever more public cynicism among the more tutored classes. The scorn of Tertullian's *De Spectaculis*⁵ had long since threatened carnal Rome with a Day of Judgment. The persecution of Christians under Nero, Trajan, and (even) Marcus Aurelius provided the poor and hopeless non-Christians with a daring and romantic model and with what would later come to be grounds for reprisal. The eloquence of such early religious philosophers as Plotinus and Origen merged with the Stoic mandate that the true philosopher live an exemplary life. Origen's devotion to an existence devoid of lust is documented by his self-inflicted emasculation! Christianity went beyond the Stoic

resignation in the face of death to the (Platonic) celebration of death which would free the soul from its bodily prison and reunite it with its Creator. To a worn and weary peasantry, the Gospels offered eternal life hereafter and rewards that would beggar the vaults of Croesus.

From Stoicism the Patristic philosophers borrowed the conception of nature as law. From the Platonists, they received and embellished the ultimate reality of idea over sense. From Aristotelian teaching, the way of Cicero, Seneca, and Epictetus, they assimilated the concept of the logos: the underlying rational principle of the universe. Against the classical philosophies, they rejected materialism and its gloomy and pointless implications. As Plotinus put it,

Matter is not Soul; it is not Intellect, is not Life, is no Ideal Principle, No Reason-Principle; it is no limit or bound, for it is mere indetermin-
nation; it is not a power for what does it produce?⁶

These are the words of a founder of neo-Platonism, perhaps the major philosopher of the early Patristic period, though not a Christian himself. But in the period under examination, the term "Christian" was not as unambiguous as it would become centuries later. Roman imperial expansion and imperial collapse brought together a great diversity of beliefs and cults, each somewhat transformed by the others. Plotinus (205–270) and his most influential disciple, Porphyry, are illustrative. The former was born in Egypt and studied in Alexandria under Ammonius Sacas, who was also Tertullian's mentor. Here an intellectual pedigree was shared by a major critic and a major defender of early Christian teaching. Porphyry was an Athens-educated Syrian who settled in Rome, where he discovered a congenial group of Plotinists. The point, of course, is that the world of thought was now becoming scattered. The old and tight philosophical systems were being divided up into sects and infiltrated with notions their classical authors would have found bizarre. What gives the Patristic period the quality of a distinct age is not that its major figures all defended the claims of Christianity, but that they all sought to reestablish the authority of those cardinal tenets developed by the classical philosophers—tenets that were expressive of a greater culture. In a word, they were searching for a philosophical unity that might restore a form of social unity. Thus, the same Plotinus who at times might challenge Christian teaching is found at other times defending monotheism. The defense would extend to the immateriality and immortality of the individual soul, not to mention the essential "evil" of mere matter, deprived as it is of an intelligent principle. This is the sense in which Plotinus and Porphyry, as non-Christians, are as representative of the Patristic period as are such famous Fathers of the Church as Tertullian and Origen.

How should acts of self-mutilation or lives of celibacy or abject asceticism be understood? The pervasive psychology of the early Christian period was an

ways → "the word" (Inberg was the word in logos)
from Stoics → principle of the universe (logos much computation)

God ordered nature (nature law) God's law

Christian Philosophers

amalgam of previously developed but now rather oddly comprehended philosophies—oddly comprehended in that their pagan origins required them to be purged, often of the very elements that gave them their initial coherence. Renunciation of the flesh, so common among the early communities of Christians, was predicated on a radically dualistic ontology rich in moral implications. There are two worlds, the world of matter (believed by many to be ruled by Satan), and the world of Spirit. The soul is degraded by the former. A body uncleaned is unfit to house a worthy soul. Even food can "block" the inner dwelling-place converting the body from what might be a temple to something more akin to a kennel. The flesh-eaters have made their inner world an abattoir. The sensualists were the devil's playground. Not unlike today's Islamic fundamentalist, early Christians of this persuasion required women to be veiled and carefully monitored, discouraged socializing among unmarried men and women, and imposed other strict observances. Life as a trial or test that is failed by the many, with eternal damnation in the wings, cannot proceed on the grounds of whim and impulse.

The reach of these practices was limited by a number of factors. In general, the lower classes of society were not regarded as worthy of such concern and vigilance. Attitudes toward the conduct of a barmaid were quite different from those directed at the wife of the establishment's owner! Was this the lingering influence of Platonistic and Aristotelian class-consciousness? Could it be reconciled to belief in universal brotherhood and natural equality? It is worth noting that some of the larger enclaves of asceticism and monkish retreats were in just those places that had been centers of Greek culture and teaching. Antioch comes to mind immediately. Such centers had their local hermits and gurus, saintly persons known for good works and self-denial. Some of them, following Paul's teaching, insisted that even the institution of marriage tied one to the business of this world, this realm of corrupt matter. As a result, something of an aura of spiritual superiority surrounded the celibate, the virgin, the unattached widow, the community of prayerful men.

The teachings of the early Patristic scholars were simple and undogmatic, at least with respect to details. Plain folk from all over the Empire had to find resonant elements in the new faith and, from Paul of Tarsus to the mystic Origen, the missionaries of Christianity were willing to bend and accommodate. On fundamental principles, however, there was no compromise, and these principles have remained central to Christian belief ever since: that every person is the child of God; that there is only one God; that we are made to serve God in this world and, through good works, to live eternally in His light; that the soul is the essence of human life; that neglect of the soul is a sin to be punished; that no force on earth can affect God's plan nor earthly wisdom fully reveal it; that God's goodness is the cause of all things; that in His goodness He sacrificed His only Son to take on the human coil and then die for human redemp-

tion; and that in that sacred death the soul's hope was reborn, so that we once might aspire to God's good grace.

With such brief, bold and uncomplicated declarations, the founders of the Church of Rome, Jewish Christians at the outset, offered an alternative. To an empire torn by fickle tyrants and ignorant chieftains, they offered brotherhood. To a mass facing hunger, plague, and the violent death of warfare, they offered eternal life and the virtue of self-denial and renunciation of the flesh. To the oppressed, the slave, and the exile, they offered the reassuring genealogy of God as the Father of all. To the pagan and criminal, the wanderer and the corrupt, they offered redemption. The poor were consoled by the meaninglessness of earthly riches; the aristocrats, by the good works the prosperous could do for their brothers. The army inherited by young Constantine was already mostly Christian, as, indeed, was his mother. His most impressive victories were won under Christ's flag. Thus, as the Stoics retreated to the serenity of philosophic speculation, as the fools at court submerged themselves in the lusty favors of the emperor, and as the Visigoths planned their assaults on Rome itself, Christianity was laying claim to the hearts and minds of the empire.

Christianity did not begin with a firm foundation in philosophy. Many of its earliest followers were drawn from the poorly educated classes of Egypt and the Nile Valley, Greece, Asia Minor, Syria, and Spain. Its spokesmen were no match for the urbane rhetors of Rome and Alexandria. Indeed, Tertullian had contributed a sneering anti-intellectualism to the movement that remained with it in various forms for almost five hundred years. Philosophy, after all, had failed. Those who converted to Christianity had, we were to assume, tried the way of the philosophers and found it wanting. Moreover, a philosophical foundation required argument, public discourse, and that openness to interpretation which comes only after the religion is itself secure. At the outset, and long before this security was attained, the faithful formed together in one or another study-group of men and women, a *didaskaleion*, often maintained for years. Their leader, rather than a set of texts, would come to be the authority on questions of doctrine. But with numerous such groups and the expected variety of spiritual leaders, the community of disciples in the first two centuries was scarcely united around a set of dogmatic teachings. If unification were ever to be attained, it would be at the price of interpretive license. At least *some* teaching had to be rejected as *heresy*. Furthermore, if there was to be a recognized Christianity, it would require the clearest distinctions between itself and both Pagan and Jewish laws and beliefs. In the first two centuries of the Christian era, movements in this direction were frequent but unsuccessful. Soon, however, nothing less than an emperor would participate, and political success was on the horizon. Although we can examine the psychological and social factors that guided the evolution of early Christianity, a sharply defined Christian *psychology* before the fifth century is more difficult to make out. With each *didas-*

kaleion framing its own special conception of human nature and its participation in the divine, with each region still laboring under one or another set of ageless pagan beliefs, and with the radical class-structure of the settled communities, there is too little that might stand as a defining perspective. By the fifth century, however, with the confidence that comes from success, the Church Fathers had created that studiously rational framework by which the Christian view of human nature might be taught in psychologically meaningful terms.

The Problem of Knowledge

It has become a tradition in discussions of the Patristic period to describe Christian belief as neo-Platonist and to defend this description with quotations from Origen, Plotinus, Augustine, Boethius, and others. This can be misleading on several counts. First, despite the breadth and penetration of Plato's dialogues, the passages containing the Platonic cosmology will not yield a Christian theology. Second, the spirit of Platonism is fatalistic; that of Christianity, optimistic. The soul that abandons the dead body of the Platonist wanders through the universe in search of True Forms and a next incarnation. The Christian soul confronts God directly and takes up eternal life with Him. Platonism, taken on the whole, recommends a contemplative, introspective life of quiet virtue. The Christian life is one of action and reform. Platonism is rationalism par excellence: through dialectical reasoning, the mind can be led to the latent knowledge of the soul. The early Christian belief, however, is that all knowledge begins first with faith, which leads to a transcendental awareness of God, who is the creator of all and who, therefore, is in all things. For the Platonist, reason is the light. For the early Christian, faith is the light and the path. In short, the Platonist would not know what one meant by "taking a truth on faith," and the early Christian could not imagine knowing any significant truth without it.

There is no doubt but that the early Christian theorists, when exploring the available philosophical alternatives, found many natural bonds between their beliefs and Plato's teaching. Predictably, they turned to these when it became useful to place Christianity in a context that could invite the attention of the more intellectually inclined. This reading of early Christianity as neo-Platonist is correct. That which would have Christian thought evolving from Platonism is not. This is movingly documented in St. Augustine's *Confessions*,⁷ in which he credits the now lost *Hortensius* of Cicero with first whetting his philosophical appetite.⁸ He insists that Aristotle's *Categories* did him more harm than good⁹ and, while praising the Platonists for their appreciation of truth-as-incorporea,¹⁰ he lauds Paul still more for identifying this truth with the grace of God.¹¹

Augustine was the most influential philosopher in the history of Christianity, at least until St. Thomas Aquinas. He set the tone of Christian intellectual life for the better part of eight centuries. In limiting our analysis of the problem of knowledge to Augustine, then, there is little risk of rendering an incomplete account. Our understanding of the problem of knowledge in Augustinian terms begins with the realization that God is the ultimate truth and that to know God is the ultimate goal of the human will. Thus, inquiry of any sort must come to rest on this realization; otherwise, it is mere vanity and doomed to error and corruption. We examine human nature, for example, only because in the process we will reaffirm the existence of God.¹² The inquiry must avoid the pitfalls of the senses and must reject, a priori, the godless materialism of the Epicureans. In brief, the formal properties of the inquiry must be patterned after the Platonists.

When Augustine visited the venerable Simplicianus, he reported his devotion to the Platonists, and Simplicianus praised him "for not having fallen upon the writings of other philosophers full of fallacies and deceits, after the rudiments of this world, whereas in the Platonists God and His Word are everywhere implied."¹³ However, the Platonist merely implicated God, whereas the Christian, with reason led by grace, is able to explicate God's reality and command.¹⁴ Now, what is this reason led by grace? It is, in Augustine's phrase, an interior sense. It is that nonsensory inner awareness of truth, of error, of the moral right, of personal obligation, and of personal identity. This interior sense is the judge of perception and, therefore, is not reducible to perception. Unlike the five senses, it perceives itself perceiving as it perceives each of the separate senses perceiving. In modern parlance, this interior sense is no less than consciousness itself, but, indeed, it is something more than consciousness. It is a moral consciousness whose character is outlined, in a boldly Freudian way, in the *Confessions*:

You commanded me to abstain from sleeping with a mistress. . . . But there still live in that memory of mine . . . images of the things which my habit has fixed there. These images come into my thoughts and though, when I am awake, they are strengthless, in sleep they not only cause pleasure but go so far as to obtain assent and something very like reality. . . . [H]ow does it happen that even in our sleep we do often resist and, remembering our purpose and most chastely abiding by it, give no assent to enticements of this kind?¹⁶

For Augustine, it is not through the deliberations of the mind alone that one comes to know the truth of God. Rather, it is that there is mind which informs us of the divine agent. That the mind furnishes itself with number, with time, with memory-facts not discernible through perception alone convinced Augustine of the wisdom of the Platonists. They did not go far enough only because

mind knows/sees
things didn't get thru
mere perception

the Son of God had not seen fit to present Himself to the Hellenes. The life of Jesus, however, changed all that and thereby revealed those truths that mere philosophy could never discover.

What makes this early Christian philosophy a transcendental psychology is its insistence that human beings, as children of God, share in the divine wisdom and that through this fact and simple faith in it we can elevate our comprehension of the universe to a truly cosmic level. Put quite directly, the Christian pledge is that the faith conferred by grace and spiritual labor will equip the believer with the answer to the most vexing question: "Where did we and the universe come from and what is our destiny?" The Platonists, whose rationalism provided the broad philosophical guidelines of Christian theological discourse, had carefully segregated the true forms and the Republic. That is, Plato at his idealistic best, never complicated the affairs of State with those ultimate verities that only death could illuminate. He yearned for a philosopher-king, but only because he sought a government organized around defensible, rational principles rather than one immersed in petty squabbles and self-indulgence. Philosophy, after all, was a way of life recommended because it would make people happy. It would conduce to civility, justice, fairness, and virtue. In a word, it would allow aristocratic personages such as Plato and his circle to live out their years untrammelled by the bellicose strivings of "men of brass." To be sure, the *Phaedo* and the *Crito* are rich in their intimations of immortality, in their promise of an ultimate enlightenment. To this extent, the Platonic teaching qualifies unambiguously as transcendental philosophy. It asserts the existence of extrasensory, immaterial truths of a finer quality and graver meaning than any accessible to earthbound humans.

Christianity, however, went further. It required not a philosophical life but a religious one, which, if neglected, led not to ignorance and its attendant unhappiness but to sin and the ultimate retribution. It replaced the Platonic true forms with the all-seeing vision of the timeless architect of all truth, an architect whose infinite love was carefully balanced against infinite justice. Where the Republic was the enlargement allowing a clearer view of human nature, the Christian was the miniature in whom God's reality could be established. This shift in emphasis provided early Christian scholarship with a decidedly psychological cast. God was believed to be infinitely good, yet there was evil in the world. If this was not God's doing then there must be matters beyond God's control, or else, and in contradiction, God must be the author of both good and evil. To reconcile this seeming paradox, Augustine addressed the apparent tension between free will and determinism, a tension that has been discussed vigorously ever since. If all human beings are God's children and, therefore, are potentially able to see the light, those who do not must be converted; their souls must be saved even at the peril of their bodies. This issue became the basis of theories of the just war and of justifiable homicide, both psychological principles of conversion.

all human
beings are children
of God

Don't fight
is wrong

Don't fight
is wrong

The early Christian's problem of knowledge was not one of uncovering the truth but of transmitting it, one of readying the pagan for the light of faith. In conceiving the problem in these terms, Christian scholars inquired more deeply into the psychological, as opposed to the purely rational, factors governing human judgment and conduct. The Confessions are particularly indicative of this shift in orientation. Augustine perfected the practice of public disclosure, confession of guilt, and the expression of piety and resolution. The point here is not that he discovered the psychoanalytic principle of *catharsis*, but that his attention was given over to that side of self and others that the Socratic dialectic had ignored, even condemned. Where Socrates merely counseled against the rule of passion over reason, Augustine laid bare the genuinely personal and psychological dimensions of the conflict. The Platonic dialogues, then, were transcendental without ever attaining the character of a *depth-psychology*. Aristotle's works were studiously psychological, in most respects assiduously non-transcendental. Augustine described human nature in an unblushing, otherworldly idiom.

Central to the Augustinian epistemology is the distinction between knowledge and wisdom, the former being "a rational cognizance of temporal things"¹⁷ while the latter is "an intellectual cognizance of eternal things."¹⁸ On this account, intellect and reason are different faculties. Reason is, indeed, a guiding light by which we might navigate through a confusing world, but reason alone could not equip us with that sublime knowledge of the eternal. And, of course, "it is not difficult to judge which is to be preferred or postponed to which."¹⁹ In Book X of his work on the Holy Trinity (*De Trinitate*), Augustine reviewed the essential character of mind and emphatically declared it to be incorporeal.²⁰ He argued dualistically that the mind, while not a substance, was able to direct the material senses to "find out" what was of interest to it. However, the mere fact that it was so able to have commerce with the world of things did not indicate to Augustine that it was a thing itself. He rebuked former philosophers, and especially the Epicureans for confusing the objects of the mind's interest with mind itself. He rebuked the great run of individuals similarly for allowing their minds to become confused between the opposite poles of sense impression and eternal wisdom. Set free of sensory deceit, the mind can know itself, reflect on itself, love itself. Only this way can it find God.

The philosophy of Plato, for all the inspiration it provided, was not without dangers and liabilities when examined from the early Christian perspective. Recall, for example, the Platonic theory of knowledge which requires the soul to remember or retrieve those truths which it possessed in prelife, before it became tied to a body. Clearly, this sort of two-way eternal life was at variance with the Christian theory of God's creation of each individual soul, and the related theory of a common descent from Adam. The problem then, is one of explaining how the soul (mind) can possess those universal truths both Plato and Christianity granted. If every soul is, as it were, minted anew, having no

existence until God brings it into being for this person, the soul must have a personal identity, and not simply that ghost-like and vaporous existence allotted to souls in the realm of the true forms. But would not this personal or individuated soul, by the very fact of individuation, be incapable of knowing the universal, the un-individuated?

On Augustine's account, this would be so were it not for the voice of the Divine that speaks directly to and through each soul. It is by the grace of God that the human mind receives this knowledge. Human freedom is such that one may choose not to listen, but the word is ever present. We see in this one of the differences between the Platonic and the Christian approach not only to the problem of knowledge but also to the question of personal responsibility. Hellenic philosophy judged human nature in conservative and not especially hopeful terms. Even the loyal lover of wisdom, the philosopher, could get only so far in this earthly life. The ultimate truths would forever evade the purely temporal being, and would become accessible only in that eternal time when being was no longer personal. This much, as we have seen in the previous chapter, survives in Aristotle's metaphysics and is quite discordant with Christian belief. But given the Hellenic perspective, it becomes a relatively straightforward matter to consider some persons as the "natural slaves" of Aristotle's *Politics* who must be led and controlled by those who have traveled further in the march toward truth. Metaphorically, they are like Plato's men of brass, etc., some of whom are destined to rule while others are to serve and be ruled. Just as natural slaves are not really responsible for their barbaric innocence, so the master, too, is guilty of no offense in ruling over them.

The Christian understanding is different from this in nearly every way. Every person is "a brother in Christ," every soul comprehended by God's mercy and love. What then of those who depart from the path of righteousness? Two answers are forthcoming from the Patristics: first, some such souls have been offered by God as examples to the rest of us, as proof of the fact that sin is sickness. Second, there are those whose vanity and lust are such that they refuse to hear the voice of God, and these are as worthy of contempt and punishment here as they will undoubtedly endure hereafter.

The Problem of Conduct

Let us now look more closely at the manner in which the problem of conduct was approached. If there was an element in Patristic philosophy setting it apart from virtually all preceding systems, even that of the Platonists, it was the explicit equalitarianism just discussed. The Platonists subscribed unwaveringly to psychological nativism in accounting for the differences among men. The "convenient fiction" of Plato's men of gold in the *Republic* served as the constant rationale for eugenics and as the occasional explanation for human cor-

ruption. Aristotle and the Peripatetics never abandoned the notion of the natural slave who, by constitution, could only follow reasoning but lacked reason itself. The rupture of this otherwise unbroken tradition is announced in *The City of God*.

For, "let them," He says, "have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over every creeping thing which creepeth on the earth." He did not intend that His rational creature, who was made in His image, should have dominion over anything but the irrational creation—not man over man, but man over the beasts. . . . And this is why we do not find the word "slave" in any part of Scripture until righteous Noah branded the sin of his son with this name.²¹

How unfortunate for the animal kingdom that the line was drawn at this point, Augustine here being helped by previous generations of Stoic philosophers. Having drawn the line below human beings, however, he granted quite broad protections and promises to all those found above it. Moreover, given this insistence, scholars of the early Church subscribed to political philosophies, theories of justice, and principles of education which, it is fair to say, would have astonished the orthodox Platonist. The presumption of natural equality is a powerful one—one that perforce will color nearly every other aspect of a moral and social philosophy. Thus, whatever resemblances exist between the Platonists and Patristics, this one difference between their views is of overriding consequence. Augustine, Plotinus, Porphyry, and Simplicianus all acknowledged a variety of debts to Plato. They all admired the honorable life of Socrates. They all saw, in the theory of forms, the kernel of Christian transcendentalism. Hardly a line concerned with the immortality of the soul was written in the first four centuries of Christianity which did not refer to the authority of the Platonists for intellectual support. Still, when the time came for Augustine to share his vision of God's eternal city, it was not the *Republic* from which he sought inspiration, nor was it Plato's *Laws* that provided the maxims by which the Christian ordered his conduct.

It is to be noted that the task of explaining human error and limitation becomes far more difficult when egalitarianism is presupposed. For Augustine and his later disciples especially, the burden was increased by the transcendental character of their egalitarianism. Not only were all human beings presupposed equal, but they were deemed so by virtue of divine intervention. Because of this wedding of egalitarianism and transcendentalism, the problem of evil was the most vexing of all. The entity adopted to solve this problem was that of the free will. Without it, early Christianity would have been little more than Manichaeism: the belief in a god of goodness battling eternally with a god of evil and with the fate of every soul hanging in the balance. Without free will, evil had to be attributed to divine authorship, which was a notion not only

Soils
are
equal

heretical but one utterly incompatible with the very concept of sin and personal responsibility. Only by asserting freedom of the will were the Patristic philosophers able to reduce evil in the world to human invention and, simultaneously, to elevate humans to the status of morally responsible agents. Although free will was able to achieve these desired results, however, it created still another and potentially more telling problem: if the human will is free, how can God be said to have knowledge of things to come? And, if God does not have such foreknowledge, how can He be said to be omniscient? This dilemma had been settled once by Cicero who, in his attacks on those Stoics who believed the future could be foretold, granted free will to man only at the expense of denying omniscience to God.²²

Augustine's attempted solution began with an analysis of Cicero's conclusion. Praising Cicero for his reason but reproaching him for a lack of that wisdom which faith bestows, Augustine argued that the proposition need not be and, in fact, is not either-or:

[T]he religious mind chooses both, confesses both and maintains both by the faith of piety. . . . God knows all things before they come to pass and that we do by our free will whatsoever we know and feel to be done by us only because we will it.²³

Conditions may conspire to limit our range of possible actions, but we can always strive to want to do what is right:

Wherefore our wills also have just so much power as God willed and foreknew that they should have; and therefore whatever power they have, they have it within most certain limits.²⁴

The problem of conduct, on this analysis, is the problem of will: getting someone to recognize obligations to self, as a child of God, to God as the creator, to others as brothers. Failure of the will is sin and is unnatural.²⁵ Nature does not counsel us to seek evil. When we do, when we intend evil, we are making ill use of a good nature.²⁶

Conversion to Christianity solved the problem of conduct as it solved the problem of knowledge. The Roman citizen could evade Caesar's notice, but all was visible to the all-seeing God. Caesar's guard could reward the brave act and punish the coward, but only God could know the true motive behind each and every act, and His rewards and punishments were of a very different sort:

If a man does not pay his debt by doing what he ought, he pays it by suffering what he ought.²⁷

The Patristic Legacy

Augustine was not the Church's only voice, but he was surely its most authoritative. His *Confessions*, taken as a whole, attacked intellectualism so broadly

as to number too many casualties. His *City of God* inspired hope in an afterlife but necessarily reduced that great interest in a daily civic life that is the mark of every truly "classical" period. His *De Trinitate* and *De Libero Arbitrio*, which made "the goodness of God the cause of all things," relentlessly drew attention and energy away from Stoic science, Aristotelian logic, and Platonic rationalism. To the extent that we consider an unornamented and disinterested search for truth to be a noble one and a positive enterprise, Augustine's influence must be judged harshly. His teachings and the eagerness and talents of his followers induced fear and humility of a sort antithetical to creativity and culture.

Viewed against the background of fourth- and fifth-century alternatives, however, the growth of Christianity seems by far the better course. Despite the fear and trembling, man was first introduced to a psychological and theological theory of natural equality which has been a guiding force in the Western world ever since. Despite what may appear to be spiritual excess, this Patristic psychology, through its transcendental elements, rescued the mind from the blind alley of skepticism and the nihilistic prophesies of unbridled materialism. In Book XIX, Chapter XVIII, of *The City of God*, Augustine pauses to contrast the uncertainties proclaimed by Varro and the other philosophers of the New Academy with the certainties of the Christian faith. Skepticism regarding what the mind truly apprehends is denounced as nothing less than madness. The very grounds of skepticism are the misplaced confidence we have in fallible and deceiving senses which, after all, are material things sharing in the general limitations and corruptions of matter. The rational mind, unburdened by all this, can apprehend certainties and know the truth.

In focusing on the will and intention, the Patristics must be credited with greatly advancing the psychology of motivation. Augustine's attack on the heresies of the Pelagians affirmed freedom of the will and established the grounds on which moral blame and praise are justly ascribed. Pelagius had argued that the Augustinean position on freedom of the will was incompatible with divine omnipotence and concluded that this freedom was independent of the God's grace. The rejoinder has Augustine taking moral freedom to be a natural (God-given) endowment, itself expressing the power of divine grace to bring about something merely material nature could not attain.

It is true that other Patristic philosophers, if only to rebuke the philosophers of antiquity, preserved the older tradition, held it safe in monasteries from the western shores of Ireland to the flatlands of Syria. Thus, for every many years, a darkness settled over the mind of Europe, a darkness sustained by hunger and fear, by the failure of men and of law. We must be mindful of Christianity's contribution to this long silence, but we must also recognize how long it might have lasted had Christianity failed, for it was during this same five hundred years that new empires formed, new barbarian kings rose to power, and new cults emerged. Had these kings and cults no adversary, what would Europe's

fate have been? Without these Christians, who would have labored to retain the Hellenic record or Roman Law? What would have stood between the king's caprice and the dignity of every human being?

For five hundred years the secular and the clerical powers grew. Conflict and competition raged with predictable ferocity. The citizen was torn for centuries between the king's command and God's. The modern world waited until a great king sought lasting peace with a good pope, when in 800 Charlemagne was crowned by Leo III. During this long pause, thought did not cease, but it was less public, less assertive, even less relevant than it had been for any time since the classical period. It was not until the reawakening of the philosophical mind in the tenth and eleventh centuries that these public and assertive elements returned. Whatever ill effects the authority of Augustine may have produced, and there were ill effects, this same authority formed the foundation on which was constructed a veritable monument to reason. We are, perhaps, so ready to note the Augustinian emphasis upon faith and upon forces of an utterly transcendental nature that we forget his central philosophical maxim: "Reason should be master in human life."²⁸ Indeed, rather than reinforcing the superstitions and innocent fears of his fellow Christians, he sought to dispel these very fears by relegating emotion of any sort to a rank lower than reason's. He railed not merely against lust but against terror as well. Far from attempting to foist belief upon the unsuspecting or controlling the conduct of the brethren through reckless propaganda, Augustine labored to know the truth and to free people through its power. This power was reason itself: that which separates not only man from beast but the fool from the wise.²⁹

On specific psychological processes and functions, Augustine also carried on the tradition launched by Aristotle of examining distinct faculties and attempting to integrate them into a general theory of mind. That some of his views, though reasonable enough, would be provably wrong is less important than his keeping alive the relevance of theory and analysis to an understanding of human nature. If Scripture was in some sense the final word on such matters, it was surely not the only word.

In the matter of visual perception, Augustine was a representative of what might be called the "tactile-vision" school. The eyes must emit some sort of effluvium that makes contact with visible things, all this happening with nearly instantaneous speed. Perception is influenced by concentration and attention and is thus part of an overall *active* process, not simply passive stimulation by external objects. Our perceptions are integrated in that they have a duration during which time they are held together. This means that some *memory* process must maintain the continuity. Again, the general processes of integration are invoked to explain how the specific perceptual events become organized into what we now might call cognitive *wholes*.

Memory figures also in the storage of previous experiences, this time in the

form of imagination, which may be either merely reproductive or fully creative. It figures centrally in the integrated and continuing sense we have of our very *selves*. In this Augustine not only pays attention to a problem that remains alive in philosophy—the problem of *personal identity*—but offers an early version of the theory Locke will defend thirteen hundred years later. Anticipating Descartes, too, he removes the grounds of skepticism regarding one's *self* by insisting that doubt itself entails being (*De Trinitate*, Book X, Ch. 14).

On the question of the relationship between the material and spiritual aspects of human nature, particularly as this bears upon matters of sensual pleasure, Augustine ushered in a different conception of Genesis and of marriage and family life. The more authoritative of the early Fathers (e.g., St. Jerome, Gregory of Nyssa, St. Ambrose) understood Genesis as describing two entirely different grounds of relationship between Adam and Eve before and after the fall. The prelapsarian couple was wed in friendship, whereas after the fall they were intimate and carnal. Sexuality, including that of marriage, is thus a correlate of the fallen nature of human beings. Augustine, however, interpreted the account in Genesis differently, concluding that marital bonds are bonds of friendship to which is added a quite natural sexual bond. If there is a defect to be found in this domain it is a defect of the will, a *willfulness*, that substitutes sexual gratification for what finally are the goods of marriage, the *bonus coniugali*. As with Aristotle, though it would seem essentially independently of Aristotle's works, Augustine takes the emotional side of life as natural and then seeks to define the conditions under which emotionality is to be encouraged or condemned. It is finally not the sentiment or emotion but the contexts in which we are disposed to have such feelings that determine the moral standing of the feelings themselves.

How, then, may we fairly summarize the Patristic contribution as embodied in the works of Augustine? In an all too general way, we can cite certain propositions of a distinctly early Christian shade which, over succeeding centuries, became an integral feature of psychological speculation but with more and more of the theological aspects stripped away:

1. Over and against earlier nature-philosophies, and in keeping with later developments in Stoic philosophy, the Patristics accorded to man a position unique in the world. This bias not only prevented the establishment of an ethological or evolutionary perspective but also discouraged the application of scientific principles of any sort to questions about human knowledge, conduct or will. This contribution was, on the whole, negative, all the more so for the animal-world thereupon abandoned to the domain of the merely useful and providentially applied.
2. Because of the unique position of humanity in relation to the bal-

ance of nature, the Patristic scholars insisted that each person was individually responsible for his actions. This attention to individual responsibility picks up where Plato and Aristotle leave off, but with otherworldly implications of overarching importance. *Conscience* is more or less put on the map of psychology.

3. In their antimaterialist convictions, the philosophers of the early Church insisted upon a psycho-physical dualism according to which the psychological characteristics of human beings were forever beyond physical analysis. In orthodox religious terms, the dualism was between soul and matter; later this became a dualism between mind and matter. In our own time, the issue survives as the mind-body problem. The Greeks invented the problem, and Augustine solved it in a way that was satisfying for over one thousand years. This contribution, it would seem, was mixed.
4. In carrying religiosity into every sphere of human concern, the Patristics often regarded daily experiences as trivial. They continued that Platonic tradition which held all perception suspect and sanctified this tradition with some powerful scripture. Occasionally this led to a modest, sometimes virulent, anti-intellectualism. This was its most negative effect, made worse when the political authority of the Church was finally able to render the position official.
5. Rationalism, when colored with mysticism, produced a psychology of what we might call "intuitionism," the belief in the power of the mind to achieve transcendental awareness of truth. The Patristics called this by several names: the "interior sense," the "light of faith," and "grace." It was the agent that gives intention to our actions and thereby makes us accountable. This contribution survives in the form of theories of the unconscious, notions of unconscious motivation, and theories that assert the innate origins of our moral sensibilities. In considering the failure of this intuition to be evidence of a defect, the Patristics—inadvertently, we might suspect—were presenting a theory of psychological deviancy as disease. More significantly, they were advancing the otherwise subtle notion that it is not enough to consider mere conduct (behavior) in one's attempt to understand individual psychology; only when an action is judged in light of the intention behind it can that action be said to be known. The Patristics were not behaviorists.

Galen (ca. 130–200 A.D.) and the Scientific Alternative

We noted in Chapter 2 that while philosophers concerned themselves with the eternal imponderables, the Hippocratics continued to assemble a collection of

clinical observations and therapeutic outcomes. That is, they continued to develop Greek medicine as an essentially empirical science, indifferent or even hostile to the speculative excesses of the Socratics. A similar division of labor occurred in the Patristic period. As the fathers of the Church struggled to integrate pagan philosophy, barbarian ritual, and Christian teaching, Galen and his followers contented themselves with the more immediate problem of curing the sick, relieving pain, and understanding the causes of death and disease. Galen not only kept the Hippocratic system alive for subsequent historians; he also kept the idea of experimental science alive for subsequent scientists.

His most important psychological work was *On the Natural Faculties*,³⁰ in which he attacked not only the untested hypotheses advanced by philosophers concerned with biology but, more particularly, the very notion that an untested hypothesis has any place in biology. We are not to treat Galen as a radical empiricist, however. He was a practical man devoted to unearthing the facts of clinical medicine, and he was willing to employ any method promising success. With respect to rational deduction versus empirical induction, he had this to say:

[I]t is not our habit to employ this kind of demonstration alone, but to add thereto cogent and compelling proofs drawn from obvious facts . . . [which] can actually be recognized by the senses.³¹

There are also nativistic elements in Galen's theories. Whole sections of the treatise are directed against the extreme Epicureans and Stoics who contended that man is to be understood as a material entity treated to experiences by way of external stimulation. By natural faculties, Galen meant those that exist by nature and, therefore, do not come into being in the empirical sense at all. Included among these natural faculties are those of the soul and especially those that ultimately reveal themselves in the form of reason and intellect. His theory, then, is not far removed from that of the Platonic school:

Some of these people have even expressly declared that the soul possesses no reasoning faculty, but that we are led like cattle by the impressions of our senses, and are unable to refuse or dissent from anything.³²

Nature, however, knows better than these radical empiricists, for, she skillfully moulds everything during the stage of genesis and she also provides for the creatures after birth, employing here other faculties again, namely, one of affection and forethought for offspring, and one of sociability and friendship for kindred.³³

Thus, with respect to the emotions, the social instincts, the maternal drive, and the affective dimensions of life in general, Galen's position is uncompro-

the
instincts

misgivingly nativistic. He rejected specifically that brand of empirical materialism according to which organisms enter the world as *tabula rasa*, whose knowledge and behavior must await the mechanical instructions given by experience. To the extreme Epicureans who wished to believe that we begin life as amorphous clay, gaining wisdom and virtue only through experience—those who think our essential character is but the consequence of certain channels having been etched into a human form from without—Galen offers this:

Thus, every hypothesis of channels as an explanation of natural functioning is perfect nonsense. For, if there were not an inborn faculty given by Nature to each one of the organs at the very beginning, then animals could not continue to live . . . let us suppose they were steered only by material forces, and not by any special faculties. . . . if we suppose this, I am sure it would be ridiculous for us to discuss natural, or, still more, psychical activities—or, in fact, life as a whole.³⁴

Galen is not to be viewed as a philosophical rarity in the Patristic period since, on the fundamental question of human nature, his system makes ample provision for native (God-given) forces. This system is even less a psychological rarity since, in its principal tenets, Galenism is neo-Platonist in its own way. However, as a scientist, he is unusual on at least two counts: he insisted on accepting the data of experience over the force of logic when the two were in apparent disagreement, and he dismissed scientific hypotheses that were devoid of empirical content. In accepting the psychological aspects of human and animal life as the consequence of hereditary influences and, as a result, in remaining skeptical toward the possibility of environmental factors having much of an effect upon the human condition, he located himself quite comfortably in an age soon to become Dark. Nonetheless, centuries later, when medieval philosophers would introduce once more the benefits of observation and experiment as methods by which the truths of nature might be uncovered, the debt to Galen would be recognized and noted as a major one.

Galen did not present himself as a philosopher. Quite the contrary. But his system of medicine was rife with philosophical implications. In opposing such radical materialism as had been advanced by the atomists he found himself constrained to propose a life principle by which the organic world was to be distinguished from mere matter. He termed this principle, *spiritus anima*, a principle that would reappear repeatedly in subsequent centuries, most notably in the "animal spirits" of Descartes and in biological theories based on *vitalism*. From Galen on, there would be a theoretical and philosophic tension between materialists and vitalists, the former insisting that the laws governing the physical world were sufficient to embrace not only living things but human life and human mind as well; the latter urging that life and its psychic attributes could not be entirely explained without recourse to an extraphysical, life-

turning to for
aid.

giving *vital principle*. A fair share of the controversies waged throughout the history of psychology is based either directly or derivatively on this tension.

There is still another feature of Galenism that would be authoritatively consulted in later ages, the use of living animals in surgical experiments. From his surviving treatises and reported findings, it is clear that Galen's work caused great pain to the animals thus vivisected. In light of prevailing religious beliefs and the high wall that the Stoics had erected to separate the human community from the balance of the animal kingdom, it is not surprising that Galen's conscience was untested by any of this.

Notes

1. Epictetus, *Discourses*, translated by P. E. Matheson, in *The Stoic and Epicurean Philosophers*, edited by Whitney Oates, The Modern Library, New York, 1957 (Random House edition, 1940).

2. *Ibid.*, Book II, VII.

3. *Ibid.*, Book III, VII.

4. *Ibid.*, Book I, VI.

5. Tertullian, *De Spectaculis*. In *Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum*, H. Hoppe, Vienna, 1939. The most accessible unabridged essays of Tertullian's in English appear in *The Fathers of the Church: Tertullian (Apologetical Works) and Minucius Felix (Octavius)*, translated by Rudolph Arbesmann, O.S.A., Fathers of the Church, New York, 1950. It is in his letter to Scapula (*Ad Scapulam*), the governor of Africa, that Tertullian insists on the right of every man to worship as he sees fit. In the *Apology*, he chastens the Romans for infanticide, proclaiming that the followers of Jesus will not even take the life of a fetus. Tertullian was one of those rare critics able to combine wit and judgment. He ridiculed the pagan excesses of the Romans and, in the same breath, judged Origen's self-emasculation with the question: "If God wanted eunuchs, could He not have made them?"

6. Plotinus, *The Enneads*, Book III, 6, 7. An English translation has been published by Pantheon Books, Random House, New York.

7. St. Augustine, *The Confessions*, translated by Rex Warner, Mentor, New American Library, New York, 1963.

8. *Ibid.*, Book III, Ch. 4.

9. *Ibid.*, Book IV, Ch. 16.

10. *Ibid.*, Book VII, Ch. 20.

11. *Ibid.*, Book VII, Ch. 21.

12. *Ibid.*, Book V, Ch. 5; Book VII, Ch. 12.

13. *Ibid.*, Book VIII, Ch. 2.

14. *Ibid.*, Book VII, Ch. 21; and in *On Free Will*, Book II, Ch. 15.

15. *Ibid.*, Book X, Chs. 12, 13, 14; and in *On Free Will*, Book II, Ch. 4.

16. *Ibid.*, Book X, Ch. 30.

17. St. Augustine, *De Trinitate*, Book XII, Ch. 15, in *Basic Writings of St. Augustine*, 2 vols., edited by Whitney Oates, Random House, New York, 1948.

18. *Ibid.*

19. Ibid.
20. Ibid., Book X, Ch. 6 and 7.
21. St. Augustine, *The City of God*, Book XIX, Ch. 15, in *Basic Writings of St. Augustine*.
22. This argument appears in Cicero's *De Divinatione*.
23. *The City of God*, Book V, Ch. 9.
24. Ibid.
25. Ibid., Book X, Ch. 17.
26. Ibid.
27. St. Augustine, *On Free Choice of the Will*, Book III, Ch. 15, in *Basic Writings of St. Augustine*.
28. Ibid., Book I, Ch. 8.
29. Ibid., Book I, Ch. 9.
30. Galen, *On the Natural Faculties*, translated by Arthur John Brock, Putnam, New York, 1916. I call this his most important psychological work notwithstanding his authorship of an essay titled, *On the Affections of the Mind*. This latter work is finally no more than an attempt to understand delirium, fits, drunkenness, etc., in terms of the Hippocratic theory of the humours and the effects of an imbalance in the humours. It is not really a psychological treatise at all.
31. Galen, *On the Natural Faculties*, Book III, Ch. 2.
32. Ibid., Book I, Ch. 12.
33. Ibid.
34. Ibid., Book II, Ch. 3.

5 Scholastic Psychology: The Authority of Aristotle

Portraits of imperial epochs such as those of the pharaohs, of Alexander, and of the caesars can be painted with relatively broad strokes. Empires are regulated by a set of laws. They are governed by a visible coterie of powerful figures. They possess that unmistakably imperial tone of life. Their economies are based on a specific currency and depend on a few basic goods. They have rather transparent policies toward neighbors and rather well-articulated strategies for defense and conquest. They speak in one tongue that must be mastered by all who would share in the bounty and protections of citizenship. Portraits of "empire," then, are geometric. No matter how great the particular empire, one always knows how much canvas is required to contain it. On the few occasions when an empire succeeds, it becomes the focus of an age. That is, its entire culture becomes its principal export, and this culture is of such a nature as to transform and dominate alternative cultures. The empire that succeeds best and thereby creates a historically identifiable age is one that places a durable mark on every feature of social life. Accordingly, when the empire fails, nothing that defined it remains unchanged. Art, law, letters, economy, homelife, religion, politics, all display the signs of change as that which once animated each of them begins its decline. The historian's problem, in studying that almost fantastic period represented by the deceiving title "medieval," is that it is a post-imperial period, one occurring at the end of an empire that was great even by inflated imperial standards.

The problem, then, is not that the medieval epoch lacks distinguishing features but that each of its features is a feature-in-transition. As it is post-imperial, the medieval epoch is also pre-national. Indeed, the nations of Europe as received by modern times were medieval inventions. Empires have an imperial character and nations a national character. But what is the "character of a transition" if not a contradiction? It is only after we appreciate the complexity of this question that we can be protected against those misleading common-